

Working with Arthritis – Your UK Employment Rights

Know your employment rights when working with arthritis in the UK. Guide to reasonable adjustments, Equality Act protection, Access to Work scheme, and sick leave.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-16 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Arthritis is recognised as a disability under the **Equality Act 2010** if it has a substantial and long-term effect on your ability to carry out normal day-to-day activities. This means you have legal protections at work.

Your Rights Under the Equality Act 2010

- Protection from discrimination — your employer cannot treat you less favourably because of arthritis
 - Right to reasonable adjustments — your employer must make changes to remove disadvantages you face
 - Protection from harassment — colleagues cannot bully or mock you because of your condition
 - Protection from victimisation — you cannot be penalised for raising concerns about discrimination
-

Reasonable Adjustments



Openly licensed image via Openverse

Your employer is legally required to make "reasonable adjustments" to help you do your job. Examples include:

- Flexible working hours — starting later to manage morning stiffness
 - Ergonomic equipment — adjustable desk, ergonomic keyboard, supportive chair
 - Modified duties — avoiding heavy lifting or prolonged standing
 - Working from home — on flare days or regularly
 - Extra breaks — to stretch, move, or manage medication
 - Accessible parking — closer to the workplace entrance
 - Phased return — after illness or surgery
-

Access to Work Scheme

The government's **Access to Work** scheme can provide:

- Funding for specialist equipment or workplace adaptations
- Support worker costs
- Help with travel costs if you can't use public transport
- Mental health support

Apply at gov.uk/access-to-work. The scheme is available to employed and self-employed people.

Talking to Your Employer



Openly licensed image via Openverse

- You don't have to disclose your condition at interview, but it helps to tell your employer once employed so they can make adjustments
 - Ask for an occupational health referral — many employers provide this
 - Put requests for adjustments in writing
 - Keep records of any meetings about your condition
-

Sick Leave and SSP

If you need time off due to arthritis:

- You're entitled to Statutory Sick Pay (SSP) — currently £109.40 per week for up to 28 weeks
 - Many employers offer enhanced sick pay beyond SSP
 - If you cannot return to work, you may qualify for Employment and Support Allowance (ESA)
-

Getting Help



Openly licensed image via Openverse

- ACAS — free workplace advice on 0300 123 1100
- Citizens Advice — help with employment disputes
- Disability Rights UK — factsheets on employment and arthritis

Knowing your rights empowers you to have productive conversations with your employer. Most employers want to support you — they just need to understand what you need.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about working with arthritis – your uk employment rights?

Short answer: If your arthritis significantly affects daily activities, it's considered a disability under the Equality Act 2010. This protects you from discrimination and harassment at work. Your employer must make reasonable adjustments, such as flexible hours or ergonomic equipment. The Access to Work scheme can also fund equipment and support. You are entitled to Statutory Sick Pay if you need time off.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk